

**THIS WAS
TOMORROW**
*IS THIS THE
FUTURE WE WERE
DREAMING OF?*

A PROJECT BY
ENRICO POLICARDO



Supported using public funding by
**ARTS COUNCIL
ENGLAND**

About the project

This Was Tomorrow: Is This the Future We Were Dreaming Of? is a long-term audio-visual investigation by artist and photographer Enrico Policardo into community-led housing across the UK - cohousing, Community Land Trusts, cooperative living, retrofit and repair.

It looks at places that are functioning in the present, without framing them as models or solutions. The question throughout is not "does this work?" but something closer to: what futures are still imaginable from where we are now?

The work began in 2022, with the fundamental input of Judith Martin, architectural historian and conservationist, documenting endangered council estates in London and the utopian ideals embedded in their material form. A residency at ESAD IDEA in Porto, made possible by the work of David Marques (Devity Studio), shifted the focus - from documenting the past to watching the present, and how places actually function across different models of collective ownership, adaptation, repair, resilience and grassroots ingenuity.

The phase you are looking at today reaches across England - from London and the south coast to Cornwall, and up into the North and West, with the fieldwork carried out from late 2025 into 2026.

This work has been made possible by Arts Council England through the Developing Your Creative Practice (DYCP) scheme, and supported by Simon Vickery (Open House Festival Programme Manager), writer and photographer Thaddeus Zupančič (London Estates: Modernist Council Housing 1946-1981), and architectural historian Judith Martin, co-author of the original This Was Tomorrow publication.



ROPERS WALK

IS THIS THE FUTURE WE WERE DREAMING OF ?

Home

Home isn't only a roof. It's community, living well, and a vision of the future that isn't the marry-mortgage-die structure most of us were handed. That's not a complaint, it's an acknowledgement of what nuclearising the family and selling false independence has done - a system built around the needs of capital rather than the needs of people. The real history of people, not the history of power written down as if it were the same thing, says the opposite: we have always come together, to get through hardship and to celebrate, to belong. That's the ordinary human thing. Not the fortified, defended, frightened version we're sold.

How the work is made

I work by subtraction. I take the people out of the photographs and keep their voices and words separate from the images. The person looking has to imagine them back in - from the sound, from a line said in the interview, from what the empty place suggests. The photographs are reduced to bitmap: no master file is kept, so each print is run again from the original and never comes out the same way twice. People are everywhere in this work. They're just not in the frame - they're around it.

Why

This work sits between documentary and something much more personal and abstract - a subjective

reading of the places and people I visited. It's neither, and it's both, and I've stopped trying to resolve that.

What it's really about is imagination, and taking care of it. Removing the people is a way of forcing the viewer to build their own version of what's there - to do the work of picturing it, rather than being handed it. We're served so many images and so much information every day that the constant overstimulation leaves no room for our own. I wanted to make the opposite: large, quiet spaces to move through with the eye and the mind, room to speculate - what would I do here, what would it be to live like this, here or somewhere else.

It's the same reason I can't tidily call this art, or call it documentary. I don't much want to. My only real measure is whether it's inspiring - the way Adam Curtis moves between the poetic, the political and the informative, or the work of Jeremy Deller and Wolfgang Tillmans, all of whom I keep coming back to.

Enrico Policardo
London, 2026



A note

I made this project while living inside its own question - future-thinking and housing - which is proof enough that it isn't a speculative concern but a concrete one, urgent for me and my family as much as for a lot of people out there.

My hope is that you leave not with faith, and not with easy hope, but with the awareness that a different future isn't only possible - it's already been built.

My thanks go to everyone who has supported me through these years and kept my whole roaming existence going, and above all to my partner Rosamond, for the daily and unceasing support.

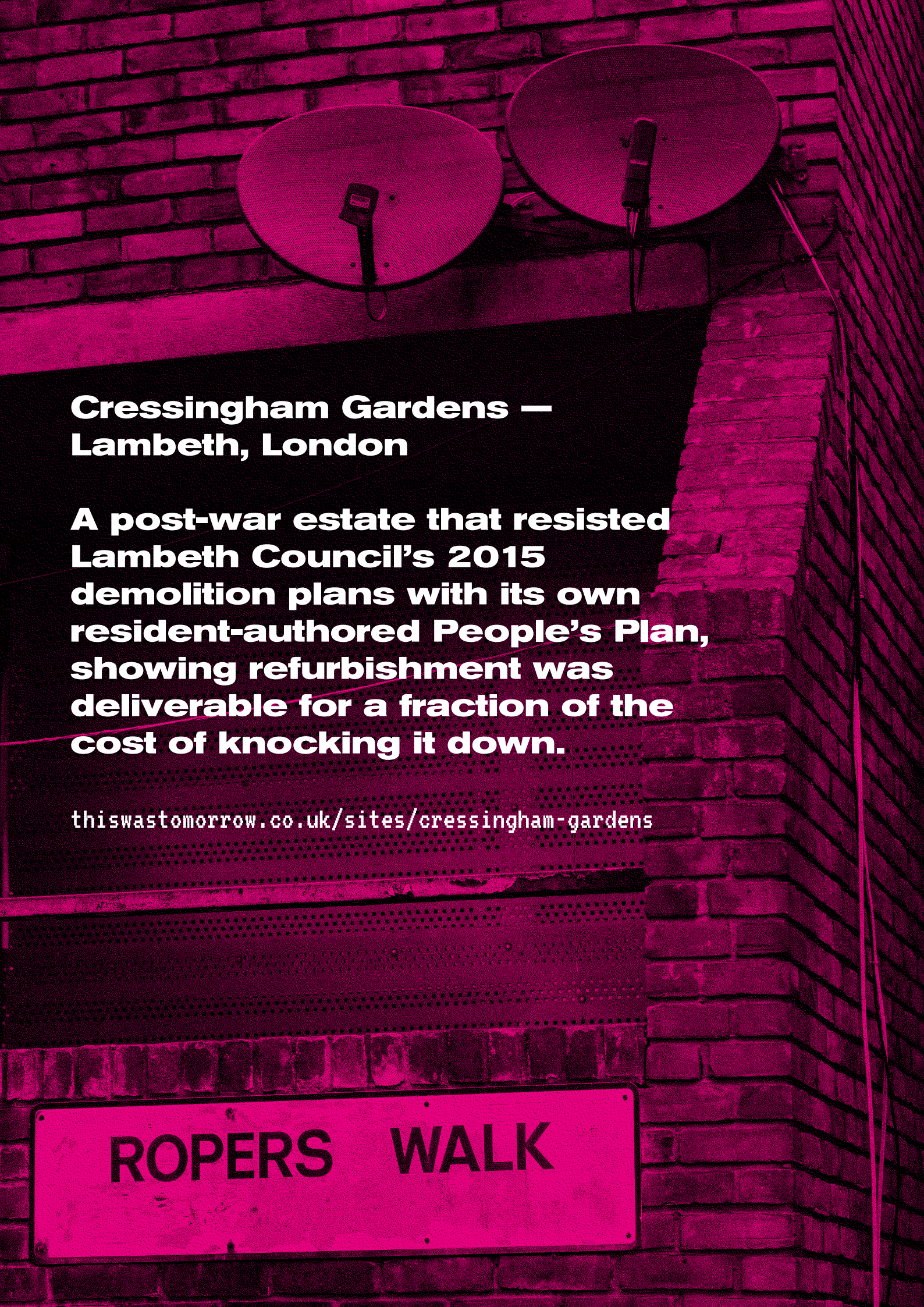
About the author

Enrico Policardo

Photographer and artist based in London. His work examines how systems of power organise everyday life and who gets to shape it - housing, the consumer economy, identity and borders, and the ways people make community and what community even means. Creative Director of ReThinkable Festival on the Italy-Slovenia border (Nova Gorica / Gorizia, European Capital of Culture 2024-2026) and an Affiliate Research Fellow at the University of Nova Gorica.

enricopolicardo.com

voices and places

A photograph of a brick wall with two satellite dishes and a street sign. The wall is made of red bricks. Two satellite dishes are mounted on the wall, one to the left of the other. A street sign is visible at the bottom of the frame. The text is overlaid on the image.

Cressingham Gardens — Lambeth, London

**A post-war estate that resisted
Lambeth Council's 2015
demolition plans with its own
resident-authored People's Plan,
showing refurbishment was
deliverable for a fraction of the
cost of knocking it down.**

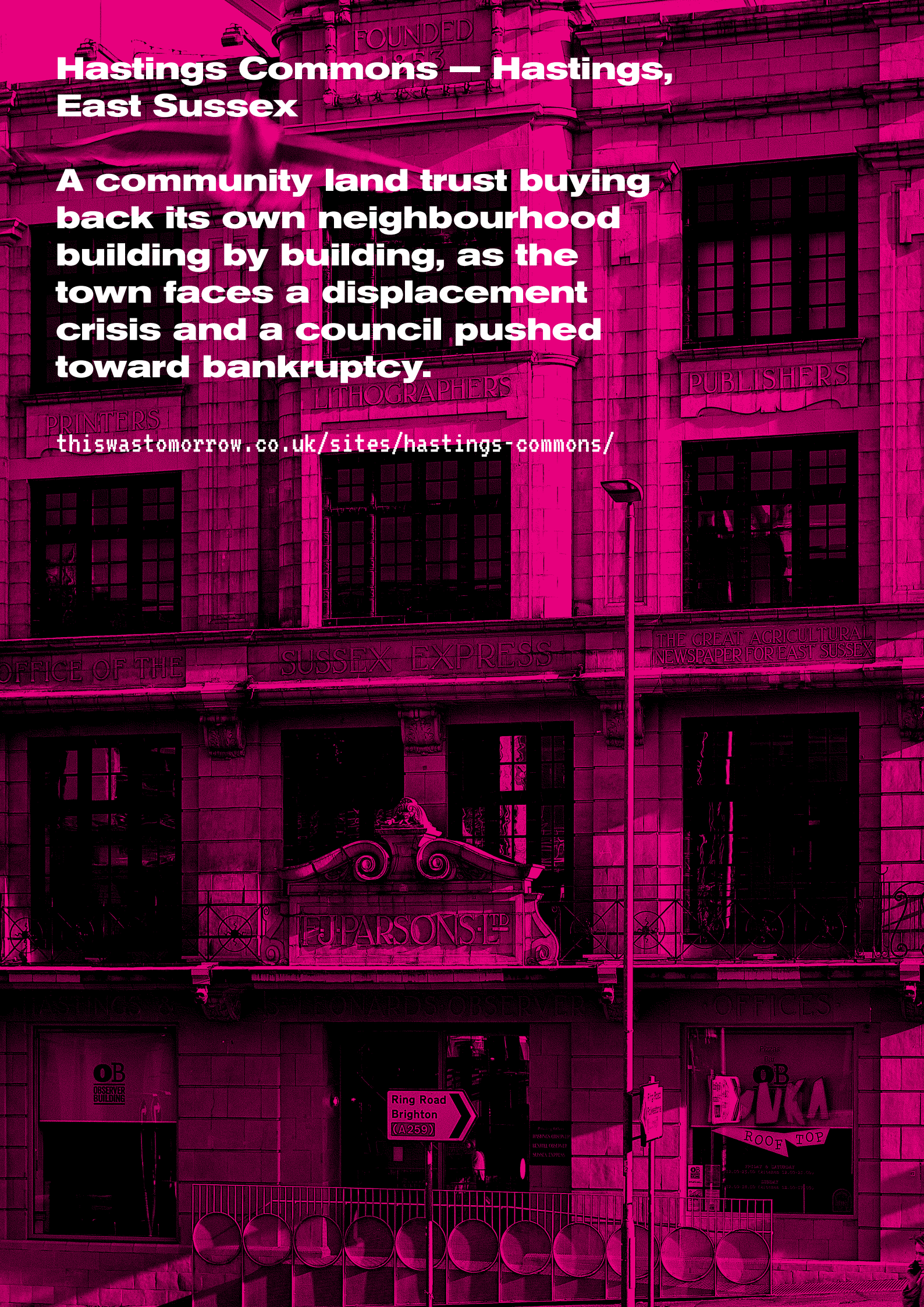
thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/cressingham-gardens

ROPERS WALK

Hastings Commons — Hastings, East Sussex

**A community land trust buying
back its own neighbourhood
building by building, as the
town faces a displacement
crisis and a council pushed
toward bankruptcy.**

thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/hastings-commons/



Tinker's Bubble — Norton sub Hamdon, Somerset

**An off-grid, fossil-fuel-free
community that has worked 40
acres of Somerset woodland
by hand and horse for over
thirty years, since 1994.**

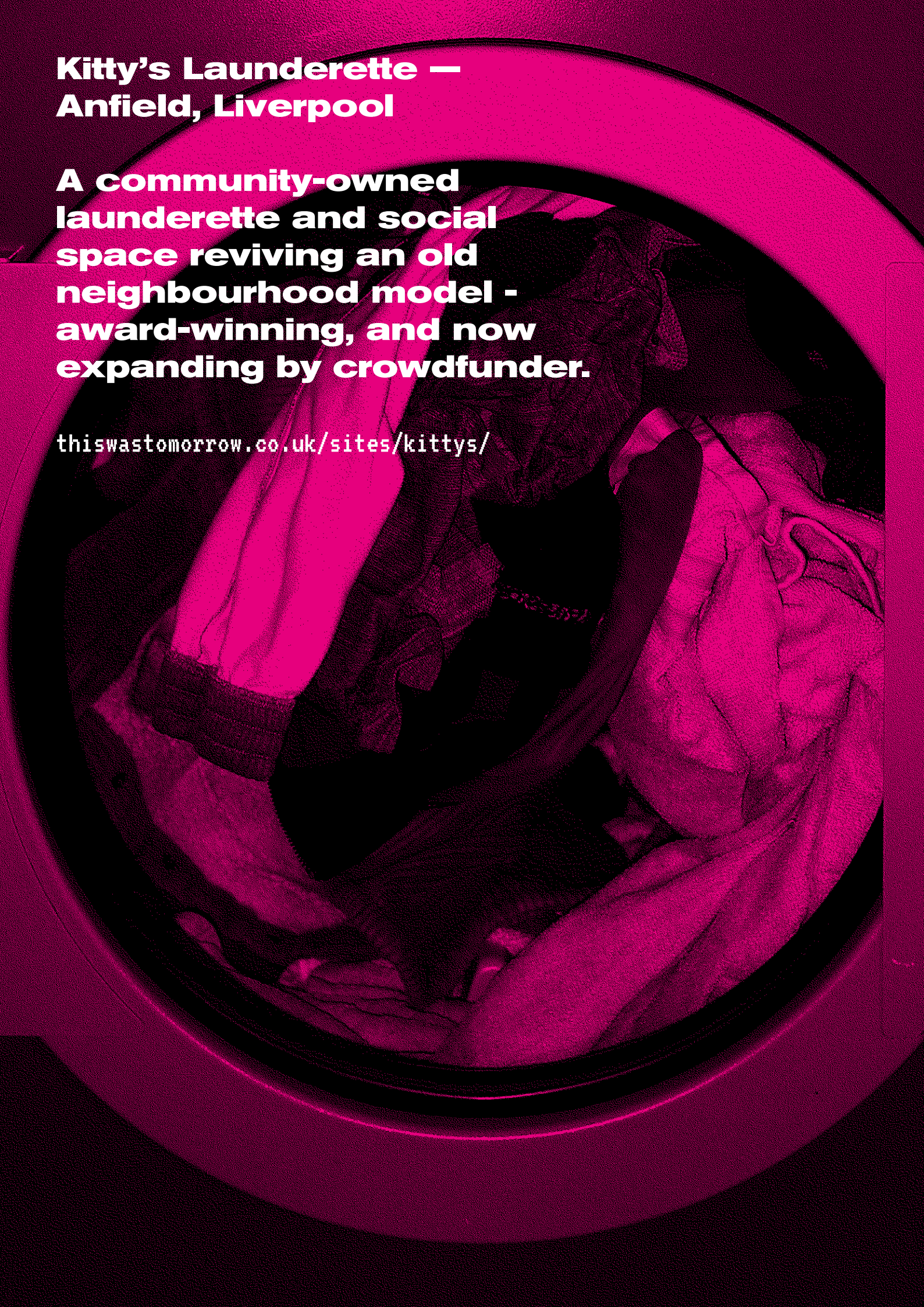
thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/tinkers-bubble/



Kitty's Launderette — Anfield, Liverpool

**A community-owned
launderette and social
space reviving an old
neighbourhood model -
award-winning, and now
expanding by crowdfunder.**

thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/kittys/



Two Up Two Down — Anfield, Liverpool

**The Anfield community
land trust and Homebaked
bakery (formerly
Homebaked CLT), rebuilding
a terrace and a high street
around a co-operatively run
bakery, begun with artist
Jeanne van Heeswijk.**

thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/two-up-two-down/

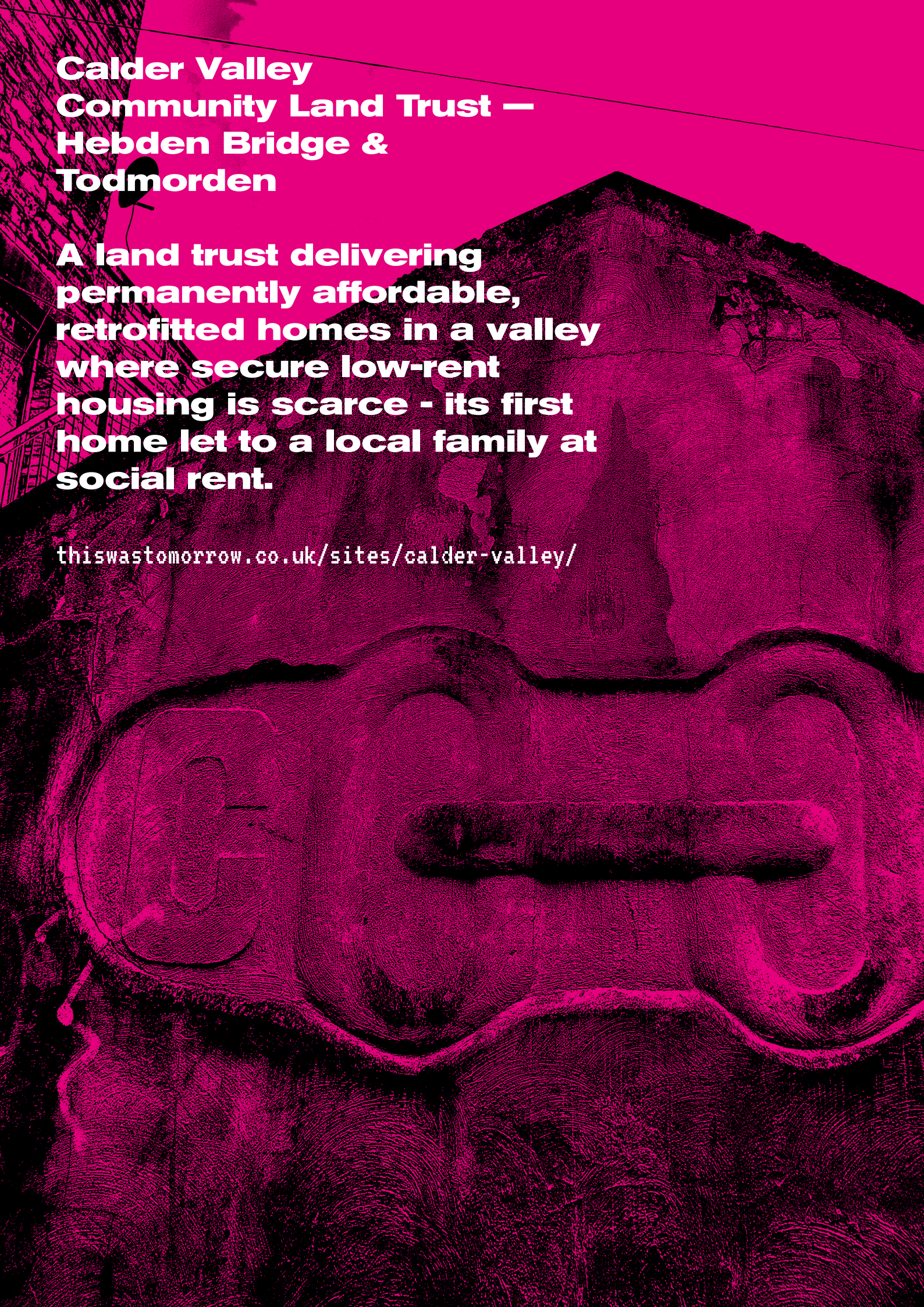
Granby Four Streets — Liverpool

The Toxteth community land trust born from a residents' fight against demolition, who took derelict Victorian terraces into community ownership and won the 2015 Turner Prize with the Assemble collective.

thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/granby/

buils





Calder Valley Community Land Trust — Hebden Bridge & Todmorden

**A land trust delivering
permanently affordable,
retrofitted homes in a valley
where secure low-rent
housing is scarce - its first
home let to a local family at
social rent.**

thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/calder-valley/

OWCH / New Ground — High Barnet, London

**The UK's first senior
cohousing community, built
by a group of older women
on the site of a former
convent and designed with
them by architects Pollard
Thomas Edwards.**

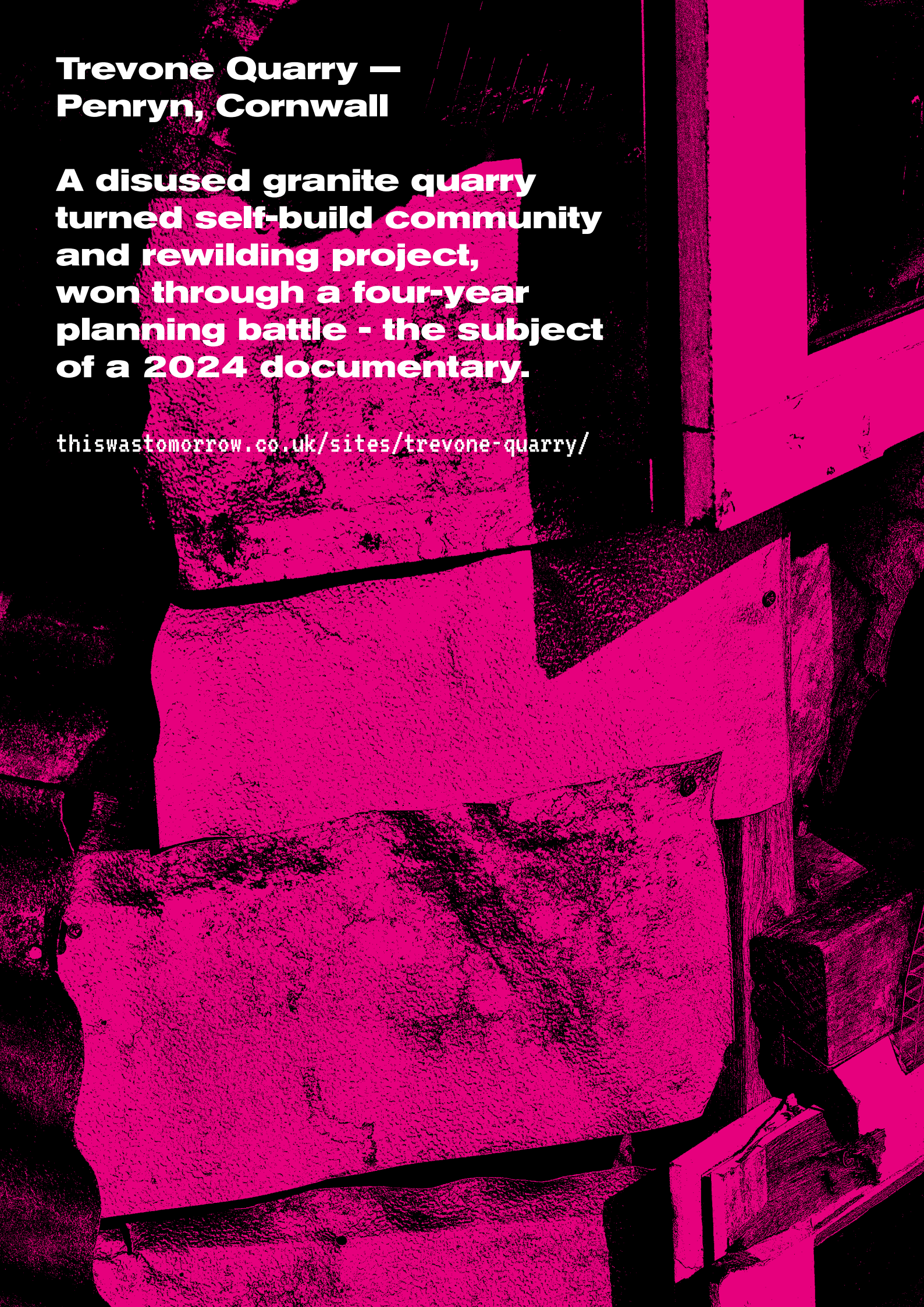
thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/owch-new-ground/



Trevone Quarry — Penryn, Cornwall

**A disused granite quarry
turned self-build community
and rewilding project,
won through a four-year
planning battle - the subject
of a 2024 documentary.**

thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/trevone-quarry/



Kesoberi — Newlyn, Cornwall

**A housing co-operative and
community farm near Newlyn, in
a county where affordable rural
housing has all but vanished.**

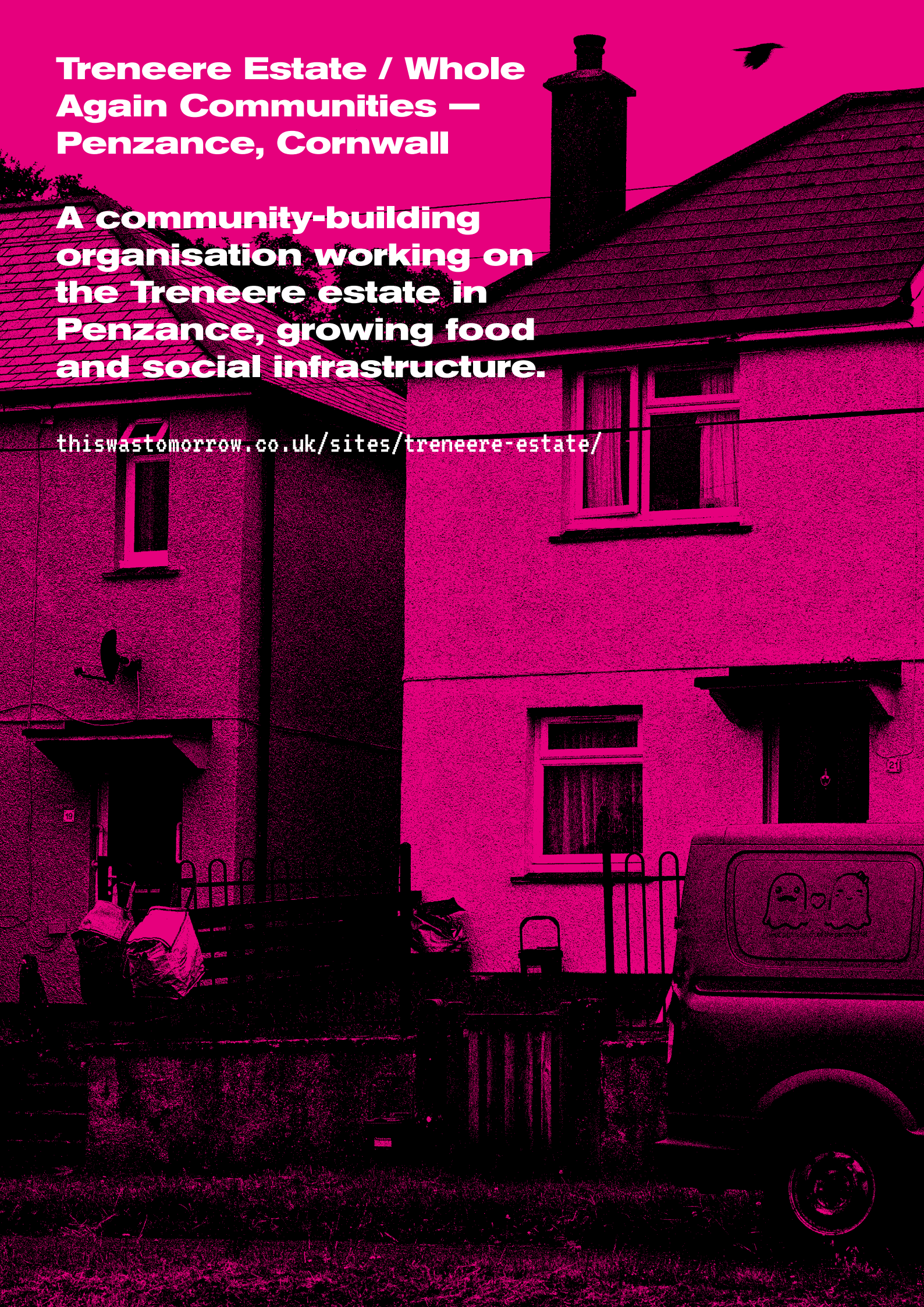
thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/kesoberi-community-farm/



Treneere Estate / Whole Again Communities — Penzance, Cornwall

A community-building organisation working on the Treneere estate in Penzance, growing food and social infrastructure.

thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/treneere-estate/



LILAC — Leeds

**Low Impact Living Affordable
Community: a co-operative
of straw-bale homes with an
income-linked affordability
model, co-founded by urban
geographer Paul Chatterton.**

thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/lilac/

UTOPIA